

Integrated Youth Engagement App for Edmonton Youth Services

Introduction and Context

Edmonton's youth service landscape is complex, with hundreds of programs delivered by nonprofits, schools, and government agencies. A 2019 system mapping identified **823 youth programs across 265 locations in Edmonton** ¹. Youth and service providers alike report that navigating this patchwork of services is challenging, leading to inconsistent access and gaps in support ² ³. Room XI – a local nonprofit (Room Eleven Foundation) running after-school and diversion programs – has witnessed these challenges first-hand. Drawing on research into community needs and youth engagement trends, there is a clear opportunity to build an **integrated, youth-centered mobile app** that streamlines access to programs and engages young people on their terms. This report outlines the **key features** such an app must include, recommends an appropriate **business structure** for development, provides an outline of a **business plan** to secure stakeholder buy-in, and highlights **local considerations** in Edmonton's legal, tech, youth, and nonprofit environment that must be addressed for success.

Key Features for an Effective Youth-Centered App

1. Coordinated Intake System and Program Matching: The app should serve as a one-stop entry point for youth to access Edmonton's myriad programs. A coordinated digital intake form can gather a youth's profile (interests, needs, demographics) and then **match them to relevant services or programs across agencies** ² ³. Research from the Youth Agency Collaboration (YAC) project in Edmonton emphasized the need for *"coordinated intake processes that facilitate sharing of comprehensive information on the services available"* to youth ³. By centralizing program info (from mental health counselling to recreation or job training) and intake, the app reduces duplication and *"provides consistent, streamlined, equitable service access"* ⁴. For youth, this means no more repeating their story multiple times – one profile unlocks recommendations for programs city-wide. A smart **program-matching** algorithm (possibly AI-powered) can suggest opportunities based on the youth's needs and goals (e.g. matching a teen interested in music to Room XI's music program, or a youth seeking career help to job skills workshops). This addresses current gaps where *"vulnerable youth do not smoothly and seamlessly go from one agency to another"* under the status quo ⁵. The system should also allow *warm referrals*: with a youth's consent, agencies can hand off intake information so the youth connects with the right service without starting from scratch.

2. Secure Case Management and Notes (Data Sharing): For professionals (youth workers, counsellors, teachers), the app must include a secure case management portal. This allows authorized staff across organizations to record **case notes, track progress, and share information** (with proper consent and privacy controls). Edmonton stakeholders have identified siloed data as a barrier – YAC findings call for *"coordinated data gathering and sharing of client information"* to improve continuity of care ⁶. A shared case management system means if a youth moves from one program to another, their history (goals, what interventions worked, etc.) can travel with them (again, only with consent and on a need-to-know basis). This prevents youth from *"falling through the cracks"* or having to retell traumatic histories. The case

management component must be **privacy-compliant** (adhering to Alberta's **PIPA** for nonprofits or **FOIP** for any government-run portions) and **securely encrypted** to protect sensitive personal data. Given many users will be minors, the app should implement strict access controls, parental consent where required, and data residency in Canada. The **information-sharing protocols** can draw on tools like Alberta's Information Sharing Decision Tree ⁷ to ensure any disclosure between partners is legally and ethically sound. Ultimately, secure cross-agency data sharing will support a "*no wrong door*" approach, where a youth can enter the system through any partner and be connected to the right supports without delay.

3. Real-Time Outcome Tracking and Analytics: In addition to case notes, the platform should track key **outcomes and metrics** for programs in real time. Funders and government increasingly demand evidence of what works. A coordinated Edmonton-wide database can **collect outcome data** (attendance, completion rates, skills gained, well-being scores, etc.) across programs. The YAC report recommends "*coordinated evaluation and outcome tracking including the creation of collective outcomes [and] consistent use of metrics*" ⁸ ⁹. By defining shared indicators (e.g. changes in school attendance, employment status, or mental health self-assessments), the app can generate dashboards showing aggregated results. *Real-time tracking* allows for quick adjustments – for example, if a particular program type is not achieving desired outcomes, agencies and funders can see that and respond. It also simplifies reporting for nonprofits: rather than each agency doing isolated evaluations, data is entered into the system and automated reports can be generated (saving time and ensuring consistency). A **data dashboard** accessible to program managers and policymakers could visualize trends (e.g. how many youth city-wide obtained jobs after using GPT resume tools, or improvements in well-being scores after certain interventions). This evidence-based approach aligns with government priorities to "*advance knowledge and evidence of what works*" in community programs ¹⁰ ¹¹. Real-time data can also enhance collaboration – for instance, partners in a coalition (like Edmonton's Youth Gang Prevention Table) are already using a centralized dashboard to share live information and track collective impact ¹². Our app would extend this capability across all youth services, helping demonstrate the app's value through tangible outcomes.

4. Youth-Centered Engagement & Wellbeing Check-ins: To be adopted widely by youth, the app must go beyond utility and genuinely engage young people. One key feature is **interactive post-program and wellbeing check-ins** that put youth voice at the center. After a youth attends a program or workshop, the app can prompt them with a quick check-in: "*How are you feeling today?*" or "*What was your takeaway from the program?*". These check-ins might use **gamified and expressive formats**: for example, a mood slider with emoji faces, or a short quiz that feels like a game rather than a survey. Research supports using creative journaling and mood-tracking to help youth reflect and build self-awareness. The **Mirror journaling app** (developed by the Child Mind Institute) is an example of a tool that offers teens a "*secure space for emotional reflection using mood tracking and guided prompts*" ¹³ ¹⁴. In our app, a teen could log their mood weekly and write or record a quick diary entry about their week or their feelings after a program session. This not only supports mental wellness (by encouraging reflection) but also provides qualitative feedback to program staff. The app's design should make these check-ins **youth-friendly and non-intrusive** – possibly opt-in with incentives like earning badges or unlocking content for regular participation. By integrating wellbeing check-ins, the platform treats youth as active partners in their growth, aligning with trauma-informed practice and youth engagement principles (empowering youth to share feelings on their terms). Moreover, having these logs can help a case worker spot if a youth's mood is trending downward and might need extra support, enabling early intervention.

5. Creative Engagement Tools (Audio, Playlists, AI-Generated Art): Modern youth are avid content creators and consumers of digital media. The app should harness this by including **audio and AI-based**

creative tools to make participation fun and personalized. For example, youth could have the option to create an **audio journal or playlist** within the app. Music is a powerful medium for young people's self-expression; a feature where a youth can upload songs that represent their current mood or build a playlist of "songs that got me through the week" can encourage them to engage consistently. Such features resonate with Room XI's own experience using music to engage at-risk teens (e.g. their music program culminating in youth-created songs and performances). As another innovative idea, the app could incorporate **generative AI art**: imagine a youth describes their week or sets a personal goal, and an AI image generator creates a unique artwork based on that description. This kind of feature can be both entertaining and therapeutic – similar to a creative journaling exercise. There are emerging AI tools that allow users to turn text into art (for instance, Book Creator recently integrated an Adobe AI image generator to help students visualize their stories ¹⁵). By providing an AI image or avatar based on the youth's feelings, the app gives them a novel way to see their experiences reflected back. These creative tools serve a dual purpose: **engagement** (making the app sticky and enjoyable to return to) and **expression** (giving youth multiple modes – audio, visual, textual – to communicate, which is especially important for those who might struggle with traditional text-based communication). Incorporating such features keeps the platform in tune with youth digital trends (where creative apps like TikTok, digital art, and music sharing dominate) and helps the app feel like "their" space rather than a clinical tracking tool.

6. AI-Powered Coaching (Resume, Career, and Navigation Tools): Integrating **GPT-powered assistants** can greatly enhance the app's value to youth. Many young people in Edmonton face barriers in transitioning to employment or post-secondary life, and they may not have access to personalized coaching. With advances in AI (like OpenAI's GPT models), the app can offer on-demand, chat-based guidance. For instance, a **Resume Builder Coach**: the youth can input their experiences (school projects, volunteer work, part-time jobs) and the GPT-based tool will help generate a polished resume or suggest improvements in real-time. This feature aligns with federal priorities on youth employment and skills – helping youth present themselves better to employers. AI can also assist with **career exploration** by answering questions like "What does a day look like for a graphic designer?" or "What training do I need to become an electrician?". Essentially, the app can host a **24/7 career Q&A bot** that gives relevant, encouraging answers and even pulls local data (like linking to Edmonton job training programs or Alberta labor market info). Additionally, a GPT-powered **program navigator** can converse with a youth to figure out what they need: e.g. a youth might type, "I'm feeling anxious and I need someone to talk to, but I also want to find a summer job", and the AI assistant could respond with: "It sounds like you're looking for mental health support and employment help. Here are some options..." – listing perhaps Kickstand Connect for counseling and a local youth employment center for job support, with links to those in-app. This kind of intelligent support mimics a caring mentor guiding the youth through the system. It's important that the AI responses are monitored and vetted for accuracy and safety (perhaps using a fine-tuned model with knowledge of local services, and clear disclaimers that it's not professional advice). By leveraging AI in these ways, the app provides **scalable personalized support**, bridging gaps where human counselors or mentors may not be available at all hours. It meets youth where they are – online and seeking instant answers – and can significantly enhance their readiness for work and education opportunities. Such innovation would position the app at the cutting edge of youth services technology.

7. Multi-Stakeholder Portals (Youth, Parents, Organizations): To be adopted widely, the platform must cater to different user groups with appropriate interfaces. The primary interface is the **Youth Portal**, as described above, tailored for ages ~12-25 with engaging design and self-service tools. In addition, a **Parent/Caregiver Portal** is valuable, especially for younger teens. Parents often want to support their children's growth but may feel lost in the system themselves. A parent portal could allow parents to **discover**

programs for their child (using the same matching engine), register or consent to services, and see high-level updates. For example, a parent might get a notification when their child completes a program module or if a follow-up is recommended (with the youth's privacy in mind – perhaps the parent sees that the youth attended a career workshop, but not the private journal entries). Including parents aligns with approaches like Alberta's Kickstand, which provides services *“for young Albertans aged 12-25 and their parents or caregivers”* in an integrated manner ¹⁶. Next, an **Organizational Portal** is crucial for the nonprofits, schools, and government bodies who will use the system. Each partner organization (e.g. a youth shelter, a school, a counseling agency) should have a dashboard to manage their program listings (updating schedules, eligibility, etc.), view referrals, and access the case management and outcome data for youth they serve. This portal essentially functions as a **lightweight CRM (Client Relationship Management)** for each agency, replacing ad-hoc spreadsheets or disparate databases. It must be easy to use and secure, since many small nonprofits have limited IT capacity. Training and support will be needed to onboard organizations, but the benefit is significant: agencies will save time on intake/admin, and they gain insights from the shared data (e.g. seeing a youth's service history with permission). Finally, local government or funders might have an **Administrative Portal** to view system-wide analytics and manage user permissions across the network. By providing tailored access levels – youth see their own info and resources, parents see limited info for their dependents, organizations see data for their clients, and admins see aggregate trends – the app can serve the whole ecosystem. This multi-user design is key for **system-wide scalability**.

8. Local Map-Based Event and Resource Finder: The app should include an interactive **map of local resources and events** to encourage youth to engage in their community. Using geolocation, a youth could open a map to see pins for nearby youth centers, free drop-in activities, workshops, job fairs, or cultural events. Edmonton has a rich array of community events (for example, free rec centre open houses, career fairs, art workshops, etc., often listed on community calendars). The app can aggregate events from sources like the City of Edmonton's event calendar or 211 Alberta's database. A map-based interface appeals to youth who are visual and want to explore what's around them. It can filter by category (e.g. “show me sports events within 5 km” or “show mental health support locations on the map”). By tapping a pin, the youth should see details and an option to RSVP or get directions. This feature turns the app into a **daily utility** – even if a user doesn't need a structured program, they might check the app to find something to do on a Friday night that's safe and positive. For organizations, having their events show up on the map increases outreach. Importantly, the map should also highlight **critical resources** like transit options (so youth can plan how to get to a program) and perhaps locations of emergency help (e.g. if a youth needs a crisis shelter, that should be findable quickly). In essence, the map-based finder grounds the digital platform in the **physical community**, making it easier for youth to actually show up and participate in opportunities around them.

9. Mobile-First, Youth-Friendly Design: Finally, given the target audience, the app's design and technical architecture must prioritize **mobile usability and scalability**. The overwhelming majority of young people use smartphones as their primary digital device – *96% of Canadians aged 15–44 owned a smartphone in 2020* ¹⁷, and this number is likely even higher among teens in 2025. Therefore, the user experience should be optimized for small screens: intuitive navigation, fast loading, and appealing visuals. Features like push notifications can be leveraged to send gentle reminders (e.g. “You have a session tomorrow” or “New event near you this week”) – but these should be customizable to avoid being spammy. The interface should speak in a **youth-friendly voice** (co-designed with youth input, using clear and positive language, possibly a bit of humor or local slang where appropriate) to build trust and rapport. Accessibility is key too: the app should be usable on lower-end devices and in low-bandwidth situations (some youth may not have unlimited data). That might mean allowing content to cache when on Wi-Fi (like resource articles or event

listings) and ensuring the app isn't too data-heavy. On the backend, scalability considerations include using a cloud-based infrastructure that can handle an **Edmonton-wide user base** (potentially thousands of youth plus hundreds of staff users across agencies). The database and APIs should be designed for multi-tenant use (so new partner agencies or even new cities could be added with minimal fuss in the future). Security and privacy must be baked in at every level (as discussed). In summary, the tool should feel **"made for youth"** – visually engaging, respectful of their privacy, and as easy to use as any popular social app – while having the robustness to serve as critical civic infrastructure across the city.

Business Structure Recommendation: Nonprofit vs Social Enterprise

One crucial strategic decision is whether to develop this app within Room XI's existing nonprofit structure or as a separate social enterprise (for-profit or hybrid). After weighing the considerations of Canadian revenue rules, scaling needs, and funding options, **our recommendation is to pursue a hybrid approach**: incubate the app under Room XI's nonprofit for now, but structure it for potential spin-off as a social enterprise once it gains traction. Below, we outline the reasoning:

- **Alignment with Charitable Mission:** Keeping the project within Room XI's nonprofit (which likely has or will seek charitable status) ensures the app's development is mission-driven and focused on youth outcomes rather than profit. The CRA allows charities to carry on related business activities that directly further their charitable purpose ¹⁸ ¹⁹. Building a youth services platform is arguably a direct extension of Room XI's charitable mission to support youth. By housing the app internally at first, Room XI can leverage grant funding and maintain control to prioritize community benefit.
- **Access to Grants and Public Funding:** As a nonprofit initiative, the project would be eligible for **grants and donations** that a for-profit could not receive. For example, government innovation funds or foundation grants (e.g., Edmonton Community Foundation, federal digital innovation grants, etc.) could provide initial capital. There are precedents of public funds supporting youth digital platforms – for instance, Kickstand (Alberta's youth mental health platform) is funded by health and community grants to remain free for youth ¹⁶. If the app stays nonprofit, it can also tap into programs like the City of Edmonton or Government of Alberta grants for technology that improves social services. Investors seeking returns would not be involved at this stage, which keeps the focus on building a high-quality product and proving social impact.
- **CRA Rules and Income Generation:** In Canada, **nonprofit organizations (NPOs) must operate for purposes other than profit**, and generating substantial profit (even if reinvested) can jeopardize tax-exempt status ²⁰ ²¹. If Room XI's app eventually starts generating revenue (say by licensing the platform to other cities or charging fees to certain users), it could conflict with the nonprofit mandate. CRA does not accept the "destination of profits" test (you can't justify profit-making just by saying it goes to good causes) ¹⁹. To stay safe, any significant revenue-generating activity often needs to be *"hived off into a completely separate taxable corporation"* once it grows ¹⁸ ²². Therefore, our strategy is to **plan for a spin-off social enterprise** at a later stage. Initially, the app might not generate much revenue (especially if offered free in Edmonton), so it can be incubated within the nonprofit. As it scales (perhaps to other municipalities or with premium features), Room XI could establish a wholly-owned **for-profit subsidiary** or a special-purpose social enterprise company. Canadian practice allows an NPO to own a taxable business as a shareholder, receiving after-tax

dividends back to the nonprofit ²³. This model has been used by charities to balance innovation and compliance. The spin-off could take a form like a **Benefit Company or Community Contribution Company** (legal forms in some jurisdictions blending profit and social good) ²⁴, or a standard for-profit with a social mission.

- **Scaling and Investment:** Developing a sophisticated mobile platform requires capital and tech expertise. If confined to nonprofit funding, growth may be slower and resources constrained by grant cycles. A social enterprise structure, on the other hand, can attract **impact investors** or even venture capital interested in social-tech ventures. Once the app demonstrates success in Edmonton (proof of concept, user base, outcome data), Room XI could seek investment to scale it. Investors would likely insist on a for-profit entity (equity cannot be issued by a charity). By planning a separate entity, Room XI can raise capital without violating CRA rules for the main organization. The key is timing and control – Room XI should only spin out when it has a viable business case and should retain majority ownership to safeguard the mission (e.g., the nonprofit stays the controlling shareholder, so the social mission doesn't get watered down). This hybrid approach is common in social innovation: initial philanthropic support builds the product, then impact investment scales it. It's important to note that **any technology or IP developed should be properly owned or licensed** so it can transfer to the new entity smoothly when the time comes.
- **Maintaining Charitable Benefits vs. Entrepreneurship:** We also considered simply keeping the app entirely under the nonprofit long-term. The benefit there is staying eligible for grants and ensuring the platform remains free for users (which is crucial for equity). The downside is limited growth potential and potential CRA scrutiny if significant fee-for-service revenue arises. Conversely, creating a social enterprise from the start could unlock investment but might alienate some nonprofit partners or funders who prefer a charitable approach. On balance, a **phased approach** captures the best of both: early grant funding and nonprofit goodwill, combined with a path to sustainability via earned revenue later. It's essential to consult legal advisors to navigate CRA guidelines on when that spin-off should occur (e.g., if revenues become "more than incidental" ²¹ or if non-donation income starts covering core costs).

In summary, **Room XI should incubate the project within its nonprofit structure initially**, leveraging grants and ensuring alignment with its mission to serve youth. As the app proves effective and the need for larger scale (and investment) emerges, Room XI can transition the project into a social enterprise subsidiary – thereby accessing investor capital and possibly generating licensing revenue – while still channeling the impact and any profits back into the cause. This balanced structure respects CRA rules and positions the initiative for long-term growth and sustainability.

Business Plan Outline for Launch in Edmonton, Alberta

To secure strong buy-in from stakeholders (youth, nonprofits, schools, government) and to chart a course for long-term success, Room XI should prepare a comprehensive **business plan** for the app's first launch in Edmonton. Below is a detailed outline of the key sections that plan should include, along with the critical questions each section must answer (tailored to Room XI's situation and the Edmonton context):

1. Executive Summary

- **What is the core problem** we are addressing in Edmonton's youth services landscape? (E.g. fragmentation of programs, low youth engagement, lack of data on outcomes)

- **What is Room XI's solution?** Provide a snapshot of the app – its purpose, main features, and how it will improve youth outcomes.
- **Who are the target users and beneficiaries?** Emphasize youth (ages 12–25) in Edmonton, plus nonprofits, schools, and local government that will use the platform.
- **What is the impact we expect?** Highlight big-picture goals (e.g. increased youth participation city-wide, better service coordination, data-driven decisions) and perhaps an inspiring vision statement of “Edmonton as a model youth-friendly city with connected supports.”
- **Summary of ask or plan status:** If the business plan is for funders/partners, clearly state what support is needed (funding, endorsements, partnerships) and the timeline for launching the app. Keep this section concise and compelling to hook readers.

2. Organization Background (Room XI Overview)

- **Who is Room XI?** Describe Room XI's mission, history, and current programs (after-school initiatives, music program, etc.) that illustrate its commitment to youth development.
- **What is Room XI's unique value** in leading this tech project? For instance, mention its on-the-ground experience with Edmonton youth (e.g., running programs at D.S. MacKenzie School ²⁵ ²⁶) which gives firsthand insight into the needs.
- **Nonprofit status and structure:** Clarify Room XI's structure (registered nonprofit or charity) and how the app fits into its strategic plan.
- **Past successes and credibility:** Highlight any achievements (e.g., partnerships with YMCA on diversion programs ²⁷ , or initiatives like the Christmas Tree drive for families ²⁸ ²⁹) that show Room XI's innovative approaches and trust in the community. This builds confidence that Room XI can spearhead the app project.

3. Needs Assessment and Market Analysis

- **What are the identified needs and gaps for youth in Edmonton?** Use research findings and local data: for example, note that despite many programs (800+), youth face uncoordinated access ² , and vulnerable youth often navigate multiple barriers. Include stats like youth homelessness or mental health indicators if relevant, and cite reports (City strategies, Edmonton Social Planning Council research, etc.).
- **Government and stakeholder priorities:** What are government agencies and community leaders seeking? For instance, mention the City's interest in “*supporting evidence-based programs for at-risk youth*” ¹¹ and the push for data-driven collaboration (YAC recommendations). If Edmonton has a Youth Strategy or the province has a youth well-being initiative, reference that alignment.
- **Target user analysis:** Detail the demographics and psychographics of Edmonton youth who will use the app. How many are there in the age range? What are their tech habits (e.g. high smartphone use, social media engagement)? What do they value in digital experiences? Also consider subgroups: Indigenous youth, newcomer youth, LGBTQ2S+ youth – are there specific cultural or accessibility needs to account for?
- **Ecosystem mapping:** Who are the other players in youth support in Edmonton? List major youth-serving organizations (e.g. Boys & Girls Clubs/Big Brothers Big Sisters, YESS, iHuman, school boards, Alberta Health's youth services like Kickstand) and note any existing tools they use. This should answer: **Who are our partners or competitors?** If a similar initiative exists (like 211 or HelpSeeker mapping services), explain how our app complements or improves on it. The market analysis should also consider willingness of agencies to collaborate (address any competition for funding or data ownership concerns).
- **SWOT Analysis:** Optionally, present a SWOT focused on this project: Strengths (e.g. Room XI's community trust, uniqueness of the idea), Weaknesses (Room XI is small/new in tech development?), Opportunities (policy support for youth innovation, potential to scale to other cities), Threats (e.g. privacy breaches, lack of youth uptake if not designed well, or a big tech player entering this space). This crystallizes the context for readers.

4. The App Solution Description

- **Detailed features and functionality:** Provide an overview of the platform's components (essentially summarizing the key features in non-technical terms). Describe the user journey for a youth: from downloading the app, creating a profile, finding programs, engaging with check-ins, etc. Use a real-life persona example (e.g. *"Meet Alex, a 16-year-old in Edmonton... Alex uses the app to..."*) to illustrate how it works and benefits them.
- **How it addresses the needs:** For each major need from the assessment, explicitly link how a feature solves it. For instance, if the need is *"simplify navigation of services"*, explain how the program matching and intake save time ². If *"improve youth engagement"*, explain how interactive tools keep youth involved.
- **Innovative elements:** Emphasize cutting-edge aspects like the generative AI and GPT integration, and why those will make the app stand out. Perhaps mention evidence or examples (e.g. *"Similar approaches, like Youth Villages' digital platform in the US, have shown improved engagement through frequent mobile contact and data collection"* ³⁰ ³¹).
- **Accessibility and inclusivity:** How will the app ensure it's usable by youth with different abilities or languages (e.g. maybe future plans for multilingual support, or compliance with accessibility standards for visual impairment)? In Edmonton, consider languages like French, Cree, Arabic, etc., if relevant populations. Also mention inclusivity features, such as preferred name/pronoun options for youth profiles, given diverse gender identities.
- **Technical overview:** Without diving into code, outline the technology plan: Will this be a native mobile app (iOS/Android) plus a web portal for agencies? Is there any open-source or off-the-shelf software being leveraged? Mention data security measures here to reassure (e.g. encrypted databases, anonymity options in feedback, etc.). If partnering with a tech firm or using a platform (like perhaps leveraging an existing case management CRM adapted for youth), note that.
- **Development roadmap:** Provide a high-level timeline for building the app – e.g. design phase, development sprints, beta testing with a small group of youth/agencies, and go-live date. This shows the project is thought through in practical steps. Indicate any pilot testing (perhaps one school or one neighbourhood to start before city-wide rollout).

5. Marketing and Youth Engagement Strategy

- **How will youth discover and adopt the app?** Even the best tool fails if no one uses it. Outline plans to reach Edmonton youth. Questions to answer: Will you partner with schools (e.g. presentations or sign-up drives at high schools), leverage social media (Instagram, TikTok campaigns perhaps co-created with youth influencers or the Edmonton Youth Council), or work through youth hubs (like having the app promoted at the Kickstand centre and Boys & Girls Clubs)?
- **Value proposition for youth:** What will we tell youth to convince them to try it? (e.g. *"One app to find cool events, get help when you need it, and level up your future – all free!"*). The plan should ensure the messaging resonates with youth aspirations rather than sounding like a top-down government tool.
- **Building trust with youth:** Address how we will gain trust – for example, by ensuring privacy (their data won't be shared without consent), by involving youth ambassadors in promoting it, and by providing immediate value (fun features, maybe small incentives like reward points or contest entries for signing up).
- **Stakeholder buy-in:** Similarly, how to get nonprofits and schools to sign on? We need a strategy to onboard partner organizations. This could involve presenting to agency directors via REACH Edmonton or other networks, showing how the app will benefit them (less admin burden, better outcomes tracking). Possibly initial **MOUs** (Memoranda of Understanding) or a coalition approach could be mentioned – e.g. the first cohort of organizations who agree to list their programs and use the system.
- **Communications plan:** Consider media and public relations – e.g. a launch event or pilot announcement. Would we seek City of Edmonton endorsement (maybe have the Mayor or a Councillor for youth at a launch

to signal support)? Also, identify any champions (a well-known local figure or youth leaders) to be the face of the app. Outline channels: online campaign, community newsletters, school bulletin, etc., and timeline relative to launch (e.g. start marketing 2 months before launch, continue ongoing outreach post-launch to keep driving adoption).

6. Operations and Management Plan

- **Team and governance:** Who will build and manage this app? Outline the personnel required – e.g. project manager, app developers (in-house or contracted), a youth engagement coordinator, a data/privacy officer (especially important given sensitive info), and support staff for training users. If Room XI's current team will cover some roles, state that, but also acknowledge new expertise needed (like hiring a tech lead).
- **Advisory roles:** Mention plans to have a **Youth Advisory Committee** (engaging youth in app design/feedback, which reflects principles of co-creation) and possibly a Stakeholder Advisory (representatives from partner agencies and funders to guide alignment). This ensures continuous input and buy-in.
- **Day-to-day operations:** Once launched, how will the platform be maintained? Cover aspects like: content moderation (who checks that discussion or AI outputs remain appropriate?), user support (will there be in-app chat support or a help desk for issues?), and updates (how often will features be updated or bugs fixed). Since this is a system-wide tool, reliability is critical – mention any plans for training sessions or documentation for agency users.
- **Policies and procedures:** What protocols will govern use? For example, a privacy policy (ensuring compliance with PIPA/FOIP), data sharing agreements between Room XI and partners, consent forms for youth (especially under 18, how parental consent is handled), and safeguarding measures (e.g. if a youth indicates self-harm in a journal, what is the response protocol?). The business plan should reassure that these operational details are in hand to ensure ethical and safe operation.
- **Scaling and future growth in operations:** If the plan is to expand beyond the first launch, note how operations would scale. For instance, "If we onboard 50 agencies and 5,000 youth in Edmonton, we plan to train 'super-user' reps in each agency to assist, and we'd need to increase tech support staff accordingly." This shows foresight.

7. Financial Plan

- **Budget for development and launch:** Provide a detailed projected budget for at least the first 1-2 years. This should include development costs (software development, design, testing), personnel (salaries or contractor fees for the team as described in Operations), infrastructure (server hosting, software licenses, security audits), marketing (outreach materials, events), and indirect costs (admin, office, etc.). It should answer: *How much money is required to build and implement the app for Edmonton's launch?* Present both one-time costs (build) and ongoing costs (maintenance, updates, support).
- **Funding sources:** Corresponding to the budget, list anticipated sources of funds. Questions to answer: Which grants are we targeting? (e.g. provincial or federal grants for youth innovation or tech, city grants like the Community Safety and Well-Being fund, foundations focused on youth or technology). Are there corporate sponsors or donors in the community who might underwrite parts of the project (for example, a local tech company or a bank's community initiative for youth)? If Room XI has some reserve or earned income, will any be allocated? Also, mention any in-kind contributions: maybe a tech partner offering free hosting for a year, or a university research group helping with evaluation design at no cost.
- **Revenue model (if any):** For the initial phase, the app is likely free for youth and agencies (as it should be to maximize access). Clarify that the focus is on grant funding initially, but also discuss long-term sustainability. Will there be any revenue in the future? For instance, could the City or province eventually license the platform (pay an annual fee to support upkeep), or could other cities pay to adopt it (if scaled)? Outline a vision where, after proving impact, this could attract social finance or government backing to

maintain it. If a social enterprise model is planned, note when revenue generation might kick in (perhaps Year 3+ by selling the solution elsewhere or offering premium analytics services, etc.). This section should reassure that after initial funding, there's a road to financial self-sufficiency (or at least continued funding due to demonstrated value).

- **Cost-benefit for funders:** It can strengthen the plan to include a brief cost-benefit or ROI discussion. For example, *"With an upfront investment of \$X, this platform can serve Y hundred youth in year 1 at a cost of \$Z per youth, which is more efficient compared to ..."* or *"By streamlining processes, agencies save an estimated _ hours in admin weekly (worth \$_), and youth get into programs faster, potentially reducing negative outcomes (like school dropouts or justice involvement) which cost society more."* This kind of justification can help funders see the economic sense in supporting the project.

8. Impact Measurement and Evaluation

- **How will we measure success?** List the key performance indicators (KPIs) for the app's first year. These might include: number of youth registered, number of programs listed/partner agencies, engagement level (e.g. percentage of users doing weekly check-ins), and outcome improvements (e.g. self-reported wellbeing improvements, or concrete outcomes like "100 youth gained employment via resources on the app").

- **Data collection and analysis:** Explain that the app itself will facilitate a lot of the data (since outcome tracking is built-in). But also mention any external evaluation – e.g. partnering with a local university or the City to evaluate the app's impact on service access or youth wellbeing. What questions will we seek to answer? (e.g. "Has the app increased program participation among marginalized youth?", "Are youth who use the app showing better outcomes than those who don't?").

- **Feedback loops:** How will youth and stakeholders provide feedback for continuous improvement? Perhaps quarterly surveys of users, focus groups through the Youth Advisory, and an iterative development approach to add or tweak features based on feedback. Show that the plan is not static – it includes learning from the launch and evolving.

- **Long-term vision of impact:** Paint a picture of what success looks like in 3-5 years if the plan succeeds – e.g. *"Edmonton will have a coordinated youth service ecosystem where no young person is left without support. The app will have contributed to a measurable increase in youth engagement city-wide (for example, a higher rate of youth accessing mental health support early, lower youth unemployment or crime rates in certain categories, etc. as indirect indicators)."* If relevant, tie this to any municipal or SDG goals (like improved community well-being, reduced inequality). This helps stakeholders emotionally invest in the importance of the project.

9. Risk Assessment and Mitigation

- **Identify key risks:** Every plan has risks. A few likely ones: **Privacy/Security Risk** (e.g. data breach or misuse of sensitive info), **Youth Safety Risk** (e.g. someone using the platform inappropriately to contact youth), **Adoption Risk** (youth or agencies don't actually use it as intended), **Financial Risk** (not securing enough funding, or cost overruns), **Technical Risk** (development delays or issues).

- **Mitigation strategies:** For each risk, list how it will be mitigated. For privacy, for instance: use encryption, follow strict consent procedures, possibly anonymize data for outcome reporting, and have clear privacy agreements – also likely compliance with new Alberta privacy reforms (noting that Alberta is updating its privacy laws, we'll adhere to best practices) ³². For youth safety: content moderation, user verification for professionals, and links to real-world support (like if a crisis word is detected, the app prompts a crisis line). For adoption: mitigate by doing extensive co-design with youth, pilot testing to get the UX right, and providing training to agency staff so they champion it to youth. For financial: have a diverse funding strategy and lean MVP development to not overspend. Listing these shows funders that we are realistic and prepared.

- **Legal and compliance considerations:** Note any legal hurdles and how they'll be handled. For example,

“We will ensure compliance with the Freedom of Information and Protection of Privacy Act (FOIP) for any data shared with public bodies, and the Personal Information Protection Act (PIPA) for nonprofit data handling. Legal counsel will review the app’s Terms of Service and consent forms to ensure minors’ capacity to consent is addressed – for users under 18, we will implement parental consent in line with Alberta’s guidelines.” Also mention copyright or licensing for AI components (if using third-party AI, ensure it’s properly licensed and doesn’t inadvertently violate any data laws). If any export or expansion beyond Alberta is mentioned, consider federal privacy law too. Essentially, reassure that compliance (privacy, data security, CRA rules, etc.) is baked into the plan.

10. Conclusion and Next Steps

- **Recap the opportunity:** Reiterate how this app will transform Edmonton’s youth services and be a model of youth engagement. Perhaps include a quote or support statement if you have one (e.g., a brief quote from a youth or community leader on why this is needed – even hypothetical in the plan).
- **Immediate next steps:** What actions follow the business plan? For example, *“Room XI will seek a seed grant of \$___ to develop the prototype in the next 6 months. We will convene a design committee with youth and partner agencies by [date].”* Outline the near-term milestones to signal momentum.
- **Call to action:** End by inviting stakeholders to join or support the effort. If this plan is shared with partners, the call might be *“We invite youth organizations across Edmonton to collaborate with us in populating the app with your programs and shaping it to serve our community better.”* For funders, *“We welcome investment in our youth – with your support, we can launch this innovative tool and ensure every young person in Edmonton has the support they need at their fingertips.”*

This structured business plan, tailored to Room XI’s project, will answer stakeholders’ key questions and position the app for strong buy-in and long-term success.

Local Environment Considerations for Success

Launching a youth-centered app in Edmonton will require careful attention to specific local factors in the **legal, technological, youth cultural, and nonprofit domains**. Below are key Edmonton and Alberta-specific considerations and how Room XI should address them:

- **Privacy Laws and Data Governance:** Alberta has robust privacy legislation that will govern our handling of youth data. **PIPA (Personal Information Protection Act)** applies to nonprofits and businesses in Alberta and sets rules for collecting, using, and disclosing personal information. **FOIP (Freedom of Information and Protection of Privacy Act)** applies to public bodies like schools or city departments that might interface with the app. Since our platform will likely involve data sharing between nonprofits and possibly schools or city programs, we must navigate both. For compliance, we will: obtain informed consent from youth (and parents/guardians for minors as needed) for any data sharing; clearly state what data is collected (e.g. personal info, check-in responses) and why; and ensure any cross-agency data transfers meet FOIP’s “need-to-know” criteria or use data-sharing agreements. We will also stay updated on Alberta’s privacy reform efforts – for instance, Alberta is considering new public-sector privacy legislation (to replace or update FOIP) ³², so we’ll remain flexible to comply with any new requirements. **Data residency:** Storing data in Canada (preferably in Alberta) can ease some privacy concerns, especially if government partners are involved (they often require Canadian servers). We will likely choose a hosting solution accordingly. Additionally, we’ll conduct Privacy Impact Assessments and consult the Alberta OIPC guidelines to proactively address privacy in design.

- **Youth Consent and Safeguarding:** In Alberta, there isn't a fixed age of consent for health or social services – it depends on capacity (the “mature minor” doctrine). Practically, for an app involving personal development and possibly sensitive info, we should decide an age threshold for parental consent. Many online services use age 13 as a cutoff (following COPPA principles, though COPPA is a U.S. law, it's a de facto standard). To be safe and build trust with parents and schools, we might require parental consent for users under 16, for instance, when it comes to sharing data with multiple agencies. We also need to ensure **duty of care**: if a youth discloses they are in danger or experiencing abuse, how will the app's operators respond? Room XI must develop protocols in line with Alberta's child protection laws (e.g. any suspicion of abuse must be reported). This ties in with having crisis links and possibly monitoring certain keywords (without violating privacy – a delicate balance where maybe automated flags could alert a human moderator to check if intervention is needed).
- **Integration with Edmonton's Service Network:** Edmonton has some existing digital resources. Two notable ones: **211 Alberta**, which is an information/referral line (with a database of services), and **HelpSeeker**, the online map of social services (used in research to map 823 youth programs ¹). Rather than duplicating efforts, our app should integrate or at least not conflict. For example, perhaps we can pull data from 211's API or collaborate so that the program directory remains up-to-date. Being aware of these is crucial – if we don't coordinate, agencies might resist “yet another platform.” We should highlight how our app differs: it's not just an info directory, but an interactive case management and engagement tool for youth. Still, strategically partnering with existing infrastructure (maybe 211 or HelpSeeker becomes a data source) would strengthen the project. Locally, **Kickstand Connect** is another digital platform (for mental health) ¹⁶. While Kickstand is province-wide and focused on counseling and peer support, we should ensure our app complements it (perhaps even link to Kickstand for youth seeking virtual counseling). A collaborative stance – presenting the app as *the next piece that connects all these services together* – will gain more community support.
- **Tech Infrastructure and Collaboration in Edmonton:** Edmonton is building a reputation in tech and AI (home to the Alberta Machine Intelligence Institute and a growing startup scene). This environment is favorable for our project, as there may be local tech talent and interest in social innovation. We might seek partnerships with local tech companies or the University of Alberta's computing science/AI department for expertise (especially for the AI features). Additionally, the city's open data initiative could be useful – for instance, using open data for transit routes (to integrate with our event finder so youth can easily see how to get somewhere) or open data on community recreation schedules. Being aware of and using the city's tech resources can enhance the app's utility. On a practical note, Edmonton's broadband and mobile coverage is generally good, but some low-income neighborhoods might have connectivity issues. We should consider an **offline mode** (limited functionality when offline, maybe storing key info on the device) or at least ensure the app works on older phones so that we don't exclude youth who can't afford the latest devices.
- **Youth Culture and Diversity in Edmonton:** Edmonton's youth population is diverse – including Indigenous youth (Cree, Métis, etc.), immigrant and refugee youth, and a large urban Indigenous population. Cultural relevance is important. For instance, when designing the generative AI or the content, we might incorporate culturally appropriate elements (such as allowing youths to select cultural identifiers in their profile if they want, and ensuring representation in any imagery or avatars). We should be prepared to address language needs – Edmonton has many Arabic, Somali,

Chinese, South Asian communities; while the initial launch may be English-only, the plan should mention future multilingual support. Also, youth in Edmonton have unique interests – the city has a strong sports culture (hockey, etc.), arts (Fringe festival), and a tight-knit community league system. The app could leverage these by integrating with community leagues or youth councils in neighborhoods. Recognizing youth culture also means acknowledging *youth voice*: success will depend on continued **youth engagement in design and promotion**. Edmonton has bodies like the Edmonton Youth Council (associated with City Council) – we should involve them or at least inform them to get their buy-in. They can provide insights into what Edmonton youth want and help champion the app among peers.

- **Nonprofit Collaboration and Competition:** Edmonton's nonprofit environment has traditionally had some silos, partly due to funding structures that inadvertently create competition ³³. The YAC project noted *"ineffective and inefficient collaboration"* as a challenge, partly because agencies compete for funding and have inconsistent practices ³⁴. Our app aims to foster collaboration, but we must address any **trust issues** and change management. Some organizations might fear losing control of "their" client data or that a centralized system could be used by funders to compare agencies in a way that feels punitive. To mitigate this, we should involve agency representatives early, co-develop data-sharing agreements that protect each organization's interests, and emphasize that this platform is a tool to *help them help youth*, not to monitor them. We will likely need a neutral convenor or champion – perhaps REACH Edmonton (a backbone org for community safety) or the City's Family & Community Support Services (FCSS) team – to endorse the initiative. Showing alignment with collective impact models (like how the Youth Gang Prevention Table uses a shared platform with success ¹²) can persuade agencies that this is the direction the sector is moving. We should also clarify data ownership: each agency likely retains ownership of their client notes, etc., but shares as needed – and aggregate data for evaluation will be anonymized. Building a governance committee where agencies have a say in how the system works will ease concerns.
- **Legal Liability and Insurance:** Because this app is essentially providing information and even advice (via AI) to youth, we need to consider liability. For example, if an AI career advisor gave a youth poor advice, or if a youth relied on a map listing and something unfortunate happened at an event, could Room XI be liable? We should craft disclaimers (e.g. AI advice is for informational purposes, not a substitute for professional guidance; event listings are provided in good faith but users should exercise judgment, etc.). We should also ensure Room XI's insurance (Directors & Officers, Commercial General Liability, perhaps Cyber Liability coverage) is updated to cover technology-based services and data breaches. Engaging legal counsel familiar with tech and youth services will be important in Edmonton, as laws around youth consent, mandatory reporting, etc., must be woven into the terms of use.
- **Edmonton School Board and Government Partner Policies:** If we plan integration with schools (like using the app in an after-school program on school property, as Room XI does with D.S. MacKenzie School ³⁵ ³⁶), we must follow school board policies on digital tools. Edmonton Public Schools, for example, have policies for approving apps or software that collect student data. Early dialogue with school administration to get approval or to go through their vetting process is wise. Similarly, if City of Edmonton departments are involved, the app might need to meet certain IT standards (the City might require security assessments, etc.). Being proactive in meeting these institutional requirements will prevent roadblocks at launch.

- **Future Scalability in Alberta/Canada:** While focusing on Edmonton first, we should keep an eye on how Alberta's context might differ from others. If successful, Room XI might extend the app to other Alberta communities or nationally. Noting this because building for Edmonton means considering things like bilingual requirements (if going Canada-wide, French would be needed), or Indigenous data sovereignty considerations (e.g. working with First Nations in Alberta might entail special protocols for data). Edmonton itself sits on Treaty 6 territory; engaging Indigenous youth and respecting cultural protocols (like perhaps involving Indigenous elders or youth mentors in the program design for those communities) will enhance success locally and set a template for elsewhere.

In conclusion, tailoring the app's implementation to **Edmonton's environment** – from strict adherence to privacy laws and ethical data use, to deep collaboration with the local youth sector, to culturally responsive design – is vital. By addressing these local considerations head-on, Room XI can de-risk the project and build a platform that is not only innovative, but also trusted and embraced by the community it's meant to serve.

Sources: The recommendations above draw on local research and examples: Edmonton's Youth Agency Collaboration report emphasizing coordinated systems ² ³, the Kickstand Connect model for integrated youth support ¹⁶, national youth engagement insights ¹⁴, and CRA guidelines for structuring social enterprises in Canada ¹⁹ ²², among others. These inform the design and strategy for a youth-centered app that is evidence-based and context-aware. Each feature and plan element is crafted to align with proven needs and trends, ensuring the tool will be both effective and widely adopted across Edmonton's youth, nonprofits, schools, and government partners.

¹ ² ³ ⁴ ⁵ ⁶ ⁸ ⁹ ³³ ³⁴ mapsab.ca

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¹³ ¹⁴ Child Mind Institute launches Mirror mental health journaling app for teens | Edtech news | ETIH — EdTech Innovation Hub

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¹⁶ Kickstand OPENS FREE Youth Mental Health CENTRE at West Edmonton Mall

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¹⁷ So long landline, hello smartphone - Statistics Canada

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